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ARTICLE

Jesus vs. Paul? The Online Influencers Splitting Scripture



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 20, 2026

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A short video can make a sweeping theological claim sound obvious: Jesus never condemned homosexuality, the argument goes, but Paul did. Therefore, Paul must have contradicted Jesus—and Christians should trust Jesus instead.

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The claim is designed to feel simple. Its consequences are not. If one apostle's teaching can be discarded whenever it conflicts with modern preferences, what keeps the rest of Scripture from being judged by the same standard?

This argument is appearing in online discussions that portray Paul as a false teacher who corrupted Jesus' message. The dispute often centers on sexuality, but the deeper issue is biblical authority. The question is whether Christians receive the whole counsel of God—or select the passages that feel acceptable to the age.



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Jesus and Paul were not rivals

Jesus did not teach that only His recorded sayings carry divine authority. He affirmed the authority of the Scriptures and taught that He came not to abolish the Law and the Prophets, but to fulfill them (Matthew 5:17). When asked about marriage, He pointed back to Genesis: God made humanity male and female, and a man and woman become one flesh (Matthew 19:4–6). He also warned against sexual immorality (Matthew 15:19).

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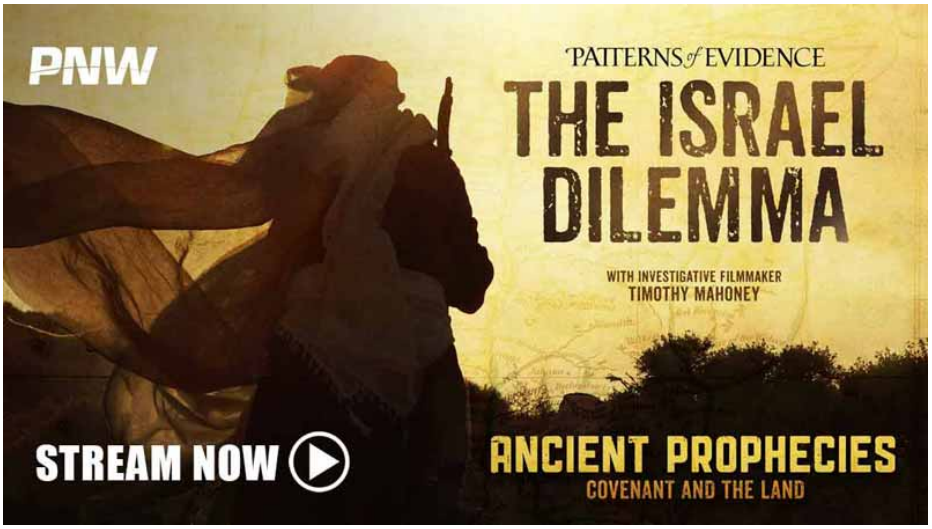
Paul's teaching did not arrive as a competing message. Paul described his gospel as something received through a revelation of Jesus Christ (Galatians 1:11–12). The book of Acts presents the risen Christ commissioning him to carry the gospel to the nations (Acts 9:15). And Peter, writing to the church, referred to Paul's letters and warned that some people twist them, "as they do the other Scriptures" (2 Peter 3:15–16).

Peter's warning is particularly relevant. He did not tell Christians to discard Paul because his letters were difficult. He warned them to recognize that Scripture can be distorted.

Silence is not a veto

The argument that Jesus never explicitly addressed a subject therefore Paul must be wrong rests on a faulty assumption: that Jesus' recorded words are the only words Christians should treat as authoritative. The New Testament presents a broader picture. Jesus commissioned His apostles to teach, and the apostles understood themselves to be witnesses speaking under His authority.

A subject does not become morally acceptable simply because the Gospels do not record Jesus addressing it by name. Jesus did not need to repeat every commandment or answer every future argument in a separate sermon. His teaching on marriage, sexual immorality, and the authority of Scripture belongs in the same Bible as Paul's letters.



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The danger of influencers as theological authorities

Social media makes it easy for a person with a camera, a confident delivery, and a large following to become a Christian's default source of theology. A brief clip may quote a verse, announce that an apostle is a fraud, and move on before viewers have time to examine the claim.

Online teachers can raise important questions and point people toward Scripture. But popularity does not establish theological authority. Neither does a compelling personal story, a polished production, or the claim that someone has uncovered what pastors and churches have supposedly hidden.

When Christians rely on influencers without checking their claims against Scripture, the teacher's interpretation can quietly take the place of the Bible itself. A viral clip may become the lens through which every difficult passage is judged. Soon, the question is no longer, "What does Scripture teach?" It is, "Which parts of Scripture can I keep without losing the approval of the voices I follow?"

That shift can change more than a person's opinion about one passage. If a favored teacher persuades someone that an inconvenient part of Scripture can be dismissed, the same approach can be applied to any teaching that feels uncomfortable. Faith becomes something assembled from the verses and voices that affirm what a person already wants to believe. The influencer may claim to be freeing people from Paul, but the viewer can end up placing a new authority in his place: the person who decides which parts of the Bible still count.

The Bereans offer a better model. They listened carefully, then examined the Scriptures to see whether Paul's teaching was true (Acts 17:11). Their example calls for discernment and careful study. It does not give believers permission to reject biblical books that challenge their assumptions.

A faith that cannot be corrected by Scripture is not being guided by Scripture.

Test every teacher—including the popular ones

Christians should test every teacher, whether that teacher stands in a pulpit or appears on a phone screen. Read the passage in context. Compare it with the rest of the Bible. Ask whether the teacher is explaining Scripture or using a few selected verses to make Scripture fit a preferred conclusion.

Paul warned Timothy that people would seek teachers who told them what they wanted to hear (2 Timothy 4:3–4). That warning is not a license to label every disagreement false teaching. It is a call to take doctrine seriously and to stay rooted in God's Word.

The choice is not Jesus or Paul. The New Testament presents Paul as a servant of Christ whose message was received, examined, and recognized by the apostles. Rejecting him because his teaching is unpopular does not bring Christians closer to Jesus. It risks replacing the authority of Scripture with the authority of whoever has the most persuasive clip.

Influencers can point people toward the Bible. They must never become a substitute for it.

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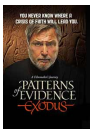
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